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Joshua Nations Numbers

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Numbers

A. Theme and Background

1. The title is taken from the numbering of the people found in chapters 1-4 and 26. The narrative begins with the second year after the Exodus on or about 1444 BC. The book bridges the Israelites receiving the Law at Mt. Sinai to where they are being prepared to enter the Good Land.
2. Two generations of Israelites are presented: the first is the generation that exited from Egypt and is reflected in the first numbering of chapters 1-4. This entire generation of those 20 years of age and over perished in the wilderness due to their disobedience except Joshua and Caleb. The second generation reflected by the numbering in chapter 14, was their children who grew to adulthood in the wilderness and would enter the Good Land.
3. The theme is primarily that of disobedience or rebellion followed by repentance, obedience and blessing which could be said of most of the Old Testament. The theme of God's Holiness is also carried through from Leviticus. The importance of Numbers is noted by the Apostle Paul in 1 Corinthians 10:1-12, where he says that those things that happen to the Israelites were given to us as warnings. Paul refers to the kindness and sternness of God in Romans 11:22. We see both of these attributes displayed in the book of Numbers. A key verse is seen in 6:24-26: "The LORD bless you and keep you; the LORD make his face shine on you and be gracious to you; the LORD turn his face toward you and give you peace."

B. Chapters 1-4 record the numbering of the children of Israel who are men prepared for war, the arrangement of the tribes around the tabernacle and of those who would serve the tabernacle.

C. Chapter 5 prescribes purity in the camp and restitution of wrongs (5:1-10) and the test for an unfaithful wife (5:11-31). This latter directive from the Lord seems very strange until it is examined more closely. A husband may suspect his wife of being unfaithful. The woman is given holy water in a clay jar and mixed with dirt from the floor of the tabernacle and curses washed from a scroll (bitter water). If after she drinks it and if she has been unfaithful, her abdomen will swell and she may miscarry.

1. If we look at the fact that there is nothing in the bitter water that would by itself do this, then if the result shows unfaithfulness it is something revealed by God, not man. Although hard for us to understand in a modern culture, the test was to ensure purity among God's people and to deal with a spirit of jealousy which can destroy a marriage. As Matthew Pool (1624-1679) puts it, "This law was given partly to deter wives from adulterous practices, and partly to secure wives against the rage of their hard-hearted husbands, who otherwise might upon mere suspicions destroy them, or at least put them away."
2. The Bible throughout both Old and New Testaments condemns adultery and other types of sexual sin. So, although in this narrative it appears that the man who is accusing his wife of adultery is not subject to the same requirements of a purity test, he is still subject to God's standard of holiness which if violated results in death.

D. Chapters 6-12 detail various things such as the Nazirite vow, dedication of the Tabernacle, the Passover, the Israelites leaving Mt Sinai, fire from the Lord that consumed some of the people due to their grumbling, the provision of quail and a resulting plague, and Miriam's and Aaron's opposition to Moses.

E. Chapters 13 and 14 describe the 12 scouts from each tribe that were sent into the Good Land to explore it. They bring back glowing reports of the land but with the exception of Joshua and Caleb, also bring a fearful report of the inhabitants. The people side with the other ten scouts and incur God's wrath. Moses intercedes for them, and they are forgiven but He sentences them to die in the wilderness for their unbelief. Some, upon hearing of their sentence, attempt to go and fight the inhabitants of the land but they are defeated. A key verse in this narrative is "The LORD is slow to anger, abounding in love and forgiving sin and rebellion. Yet he does not leave the guilty unpunished" (14:18a).

F. Chapters 15-21.

1. Supplementary offerings and unintentional sin (15).
2. The rebellion of Korah, Dathan and Abiram (16).
3. Staffs of the leaders of all 12 tribes are placed in the Tabernacle. Only Aaron's staff had budded showing that this was a sign to the rebellious (17).
4. Duties and offerings for the priests and Levites (18).
5. The Red Heifer and the water of cleansing (19).

6. Chapter 20.

- a. The Israelites arrive at the Desert of Zin. Miriam dies and is buried. The people grumble because of lack of water. Moses is told by the Lord to speak to the rock but he strikes it instead, resulting in God's judgement that he will not enter the promised land.
 - b. In both the Old and the New Testaments, Jesus is described as the Rock (Psalm 118:22; Isaiah 8:14; 28:16; Daniel 2:24; and 1 Peter 2:4). Paul references the Israelites drinking from this rock in 1 Corinthians 10:4: "and all drank the same spiritual drink, for they were drinking from a spiritual rock which followed them; and the rock was Christ."
 - c. In the Gospel of John, Jesus tells us: "If anyone is thirsty, let him come to me and drink. He who believes in Me, as the Scriptures said, 'From his innermost being will flow rivers of living water.' But this He spoke of the Spirit, whom those who believed in Him were to receive; for the Spirit was not yet given, because Jesus was not yet glorified" (7:37-39).
 - d. Christ was "struck" once upon the Cross. Today, we just need to "speak" to Jesus and living water will flow. Aaron dies at Mount Hor and is mourned by the people for 30 days.
7. In chapter 21, another incident occurs which represents Christ. Again, the people are grumbling about their conditions. God sends fiery snakes among them and many died. They repent and the Lord instructs Moses to construct a bronze snake and put it upon a pole. Anyone who looked at it would live. Jesus refers to this incident in speaking to Nicodemus in John 3:14-15: "Just as Moses lifted up the snake in the wilderness, so the Son of Man must be lifted up, that everyone who believes may have eternal life in him."

G. Chapters 22-25 describe the prophet Balaam who is summoned by the King of Moab, Balak who instructs him to curse Israel with the promise of a reward if he does so.

1. Balak takes Balaam to three different sites overlooking where Israel is camped on the plains of Moab. But all that Balaam can do is to bless Israel. The Spirit of God comes upon him and he utters the star prophecy pertaining to the coming Messiah, "A star will come out of Jacob; a scepter will rise out of Israel" (24:17). This prophecy was fulfilled when the Magi came from the east following the star asking "Where is the one who has been born king of the Jews? We saw his star

when it rose and have come to worship him.” (Matthew 2:2). Jesus refers to himself as the bright Morning Star (Revelation 22:16). The Morning Star comes after a long dark night just as Jesus will return after the long dark centuries since His ascension.

2. Balak sends Balaam away without a reward. Apparently, later Balaam, in order to get a reward, instructed Balak to entice the Israelite men with Moabite women to commit sexual immorality and to worship the false god Baal (Revelation 2:14). This resulted in a plague that killed 24,000 (25:9). The plague is stopped when Phinehas, an Israelite priest kills a man (Zimri) who had brought a Midianite woman (Kozbi) into the camp. Phinehas killed both of them with a spear (25:6-8). That Scripture provides such detail as their names proves that this was a factual event and not myth as is the case with other false religion narratives. Peter refers to Balaam as someone who loved “the wages of wickedness (2 Peter 2:15). The Israelites later kill Balaam with the sword (31:8).

H. Chapters 26 through 36.

1. The second census of those men who are able to go to war age, 20 or more (Chapter 26).
2. Provision for inheritance for those men who die without a son. Moses is instructed to lay hands upon Joshua as his successor (Chapter 27).
3. Various offerings, festivals (Chapters 28-30).
4. Vengeance upon the Midianites (Chapter 31).
5. The Reubenites and the Gadites are promised lands in the Jordan side if they promise to go along with their fellow Israelites to battle in the Good Land (Chapter 32).
6. The stages in the Israelites journey and the instruction to drive out the inhabitants of the land and to destroy their idols, images and high places plus a warning if they do not (Chapter 33).
7. The boundaries of the Good Land are established along with assignment of men to oversee the inheritance (Chapter 34).
8. Provision for the towns of the Levites is given along with instructions on towns of refuge. Someone who killed another person could flee to one of six cities where the avenger of the slain could not kill him until he faced trial. If found innocent, he could remain in the city but could not leave it or face death from the avenger

until the death of the High Priest. This is one more type of Christ where we flee to Him to escape destruction of our souls in Hell (Matthew 10:28; Hebrews 6:18).

9. The book of Numbers concludes with “These are the commands and regulations the LORD gave through Moses to the Israelites on the plains of Moab by the Jordan across from Jericho” (36:13).

I. Discussion questions, application and passing it on.

1. Are you able to present the gospel from the Book of Numbers? Consider Christ as the Rock, the bronze snake on a pole, the prophecy of the star and the refuge cities.
2. In Numbers, we see a continuation of the emphasis regarding the Holiness of God and the result if this Holiness is not respected. Do you have an appropriate respect of God’s Holiness?
3. God instructs the Israelites in some instances to kill the Canaanites and elsewhere to drive them out. Why did he do that?
4. The first generation of Israelites that left Egypt all died in the Wilderness due to their rebellion of not believing that God would deliver the land to them thereby losing their inheritance. The Apostle Paul lists a number of sins in Galatians chapter five, Ephesians chapter five and 1 Corinthians chapter six that could cause us to not inherit the kingdom of God. Note that he does not say “not enter” the kingdom of God. Is it possible that if we continue in those types of sins without repentance that we could lose our inheritance of ruling and reigning with Christ, but still be in His kingdom? Also, consider 1 Corinthians 3:10-15.

This Old Testament survey was provided by Joshua Nations (JoshuaNations.org)